First Week at the Gym: A Beginner's Playbook

Exactly what to do on Day 1 through Day 7 — no guessing, no intimidation

Sweat Cult

> **Important.** This playbook is general fitness information from an ISSA-certified personal trainer. It is not medical advice and does not replace your doctor. Check with your doctor before starting a new exercise program, especially if you have an injury, a medical condition, are pregnant, or have been told to limit exercise. Stop any exercise that causes sharp pain. No specific result is promised or guaranteed.

How to use this playbook

You joined a gym (or you're about to) and you don't know what to do when you walk in. That is the most common reason beginners quit in the first few weeks — not laziness, not lack of willpower. It's having no plan.

This playbook gives you one plan for seven days. You will:

- Know what to bring and what to wear.
- Walk the gym once with nothing to prove.
- Do three short, simple full-body workouts on machines and light weights.
- Have scripts for the awkward moments ("Are you using this?").
- Finish the week with a clear next step.

You do not need to do this perfectly. Done is better than perfect. If you miss a day, do that day next. Don't double up.

Time needed: about 20 minutes on Day 1, and about 35–45 minutes on each workout day.

Part 1 — Before you go

What to bring

- Water bottle
- Small towel (optional, but nice)
- Headphones (optional — see the etiquette section)
- Your phone, with the log from this playbook (printed, or a notes app)
- A lock, if the gym uses lockers

What to wear

- Shoes with flat, firm soles. Running shoes are fine for this week.
- Clothes you can move in freely. If you can squat and reach overhead comfortably, you're set.
- Nothing fancy. No one is judging your outfit; most people are focused on their own workout.

When to go

Pick a time when your gym is quieter, if you can. For many gyms that's mid-morning, early afternoon, or late evening, but every gym is different. On Day 1, notice when it's busy and when it isn't — that's useful information.

The mindset that works

For week one, your only goal is **to show up three times and leave feeling like you could have done a little more.** Not exhausted. Not sore for days. You are building a habit first and strength second.

Part 2 — Gym basics in plain English

The layout (most gyms)

1. **Cardio area:** treadmills, bikes, ellipticals, rowers.
2. **Machine area:** weight machines where you sit or lie down and move a handle or pad. These are the best place for beginners because the machine guides the movement.
3. **Free-weight area:** dumbbells, benches, racks, barbells. You'll use light dumbbells this week.
4. **Cable area:** a column of weight plates connected by cables to handles.
5. **Stretching/functional area:** mats, foam rollers, light equipment.

Etiquette that makes you look like a regular

- **Wipe down** any bench or machine after you use it.
- **Re-rack** dumbbells and plates where you found them.
- **Don't hover.** If someone is resting between sets, you can ask: "Are you still using this, or can I work in?"
- **Between sets:** step off the machine if you're checking your phone for more than a minute.
- **Don't film other people** without asking.
- **Headphones:** if you wear them, assume people can't hear you. A small wave or tap on the shoulder gets attention.

Scripts for awkward moments

- *Someone is on the machine you need:* "Hey, how many sets do you have left? I'd like to work in when you're done."
- *You need help setting a weight pin:* "Hi, could you show me how to adjust this?" (Most people are glad to help.)
- *You feel stuck and want to leave:* "I'm going to do one more machine, then I'm done." Finish that one, then leave. Leaving on your own terms counts as a win.
- *Someone gives unsolicited advice:* "Thanks, I'm following a plan from my trainer." (True — it's this one.)

Part 3 — The seven days

Day 1 — Walk-through (about 20 minutes)

You are **not working out hard today.** You're learning the building.

1. Check in. Find the locker room and water fountain.
2. Walk the whole floor once. Say hello to the staff if you want.
3. Find these six machines: **leg press, chest press, seated row, lat pulldown, shoulder press, and the cable station.**
4. Ride a bike or walk on the treadmill for **10 minutes** at an easy pace — you should be able to talk.
5. Try each of the six machines with **the lightest weight, 5 slow reps.** Don't count it as a workout; it's practice.
6. Leave. Write one sentence in your log: "Day 1 done."

Day 2 — Workout A, Machines (35–45 minutes)

Warm-up (5 min): easy bike or walk.

#	Exercise	Sets × reps	Rest
1	Leg press	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
2	Machine chest press	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
3	Seated cable row	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
4	Machine shoulder press	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
5	Plank (on knees or toes)	2 × 15–20 sec	45 sec

How hard? Pick a weight where the last 2 reps feel challenging but your form stays smooth. If you could do 5 more reps, it's too light. If your form falls apart, it's too heavy.

Cool-down (3–5 min): easy walk and gentle stretching of whatever feels tight.

Day 3 — Rest or easy walk

A 15–30 minute walk is plenty. Soreness is normal; sharp or joint pain is not (stop and see a professional if it continues).

Day 4 — Workout B, Dumbbells + cable (35–45 minutes)

Warm-up (5 min): easy bike or walk.

#	Exercise	Sets × reps	Rest
1	Goblet squat (light dumbbell held at chest)	2 × 8–10	60–90 sec
2	Lat pulldown	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
3	Dumbbell Romanian deadlift (light)	2 × 10	60–90 sec
4	Incline push-up on a bench	2 × 6–10	60–90 sec
5	Cable face pull (light)	2 × 12–15	60 sec

Day 5 — Rest

Walk, stretch, drink water, sleep. Rest is part of the plan.

Day 6 — Workout C, Mixed (35–45 minutes)

Warm-up (5 min): easy bike or walk.

#	Exercise	Sets × reps	Rest
1	Leg press	2 × 12	60–90 sec
2	One-arm dumbbell row (hand on bench)	2 × 10 per side	60 sec
3	Machine or dumbbell chest press	2 × 10–12	60–90 sec
4	Glute bridge	2 × 12	60 sec
5	Farmer carry (light dumbbells, walk 30 sec)	2 rounds	60 sec

Day 7 — Review (10 minutes, no gym needed)

Answer these in your log:

1. Which workout felt best? Which felt worst?
2. What did you do that you thought you couldn't?
3. What would make next week easier (a different time of day, a gym buddy, a lighter weight)?
4. Which three days next week will you go?

If you finished three workouts, you're no longer a person who "doesn't know what to do at the gym." You've done it.

Part 4 — Machine set-up cheat sheet

For every machine: **start light**, adjust the seat so the handles line up with the middle of your chest (or the pad lines up with the target joint), and move slowly.

Leg press

- Sit back, feet shoulder-width on the plate, toes slightly out.
- Lower the plate until your knees are bent comfortably (don't let your lower back lift off the pad).

- Push through your whole foot. Don’t fully lock your knees at the top.

Machine chest press

- Adjust the seat so the handles are about mid-chest height.
- Keep your shoulders down and back against the pad.
- Press out without locking your elbows; lower slowly.

Seated cable row

- Sit tall with a slight bend in your knees.
- Pull the handle toward your belly button, squeezing your shoulder blades.
- Don’t lean back far; let your arms stretch forward under control.

Lat pulldown

- Set the thigh pad so your legs are held snugly.
- Grip slightly wider than your shoulders; lean back a little.
- Pull the bar toward your upper chest; return slowly.

Machine shoulder press

- Seat height: handles at about shoulder level.
- Press up without arching your lower back.
- Lower slowly to shoulder level.

Cable station (face pull)

- Set the rope at about upper-chest/face height.
- Use a light weight. Pull the rope toward your face, elbows high.
- Pause for one second; return slowly.

Part 5 — Nerves, doubts, and “what if”

“Everyone is looking at me.” Most people are looking at themselves or their phones. The few who notice you are usually thinking, “good for them for starting.”

“I’m in the way.” Learn the quiet times. If you need a machine, ask. Gyms expect it.

“I’m too out of shape.” Gyms are for people who want to get in better shape. You’re exactly who they’re for.

“I don’t know if I’m doing it right.” Use the cheat sheet, use light weights, and ask staff to check your set-up. A good rule: if the movement is smooth and controlled and you feel the target muscle working, you’re on the right track. If something hurts sharply, stop.

“I skipped a day.” Resume at the next workout. Don’t make up for it by doing two.

“I’m not seeing changes yet.” One week is not enough time to judge your body. The only thing to measure this week is whether you showed up.

Part 6 — Your log and checklist

Print this page or copy it to your notes app.

Week 1 checklist

- [ ] Day 1 — Walk-through done
- [ ] Day 2 — Workout A done
- [ ] Day 3 — Rest/walk
- [ ] Day 4 — Workout B done
- [ ] Day 5 — Rest
- [ ] Day 6 — Workout C done
- [ ] Day 7 — Review done

Workout log

Exercise	Weight used	Sets × reps done	How did it feel? (easy / right / hard)

Rule for next week: when you can do all your reps with smooth form and it feels easy, increase the weight by the smallest amount available.

What comes next

You now have the habit started. For Week 2 and beyond, you have options:

- **Repeat this week once or twice,** adding a little weight when it feels easy.
- **Move to a structured 3-day plan** with exercise swaps and a Sunday plan each week.
- **Join Gym Starter,** a small founding cohort where a certified trainer sends you a weekly plan and checks in with you.

Learn more at **sweatcult.shop**.

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